The Smart, Circular Home: Who Gets to Decide?

These three did not share a stage. Alaylo spoke on the AI panel, Sinha on the manufacturing panel, Chitkara in a fireside chat. Put their arguments side by side, though, and the same shape appears three times: a company deciding what it will not decide on the customer's behalf.

Alaylo's version is the most counterintuitive coming from a connected-devices business. His test for good AI is that nobody notices it – if a feature has to be marketed before anyone will use it, it is not working. He used security cameras as the example. An older camera alerted on any movement, so a passing scooter and an intruder produced the same buzz. AI's job is to tell those apart and stay quiet about the scooter. But he drew the line firmly at automation that starts choosing: configuration belongs to the person who owns the device.

Chitkara applies the same principle to the replacement cycle, which is a costlier place to apply it. LG's position is that a product outliving its category's refresh rate is a loyalty asset rather than a lost sale – no throttled software, no vanishing spares. When people do upgrade a working appliance, he argued, the reason is aspiration rather than failure: a new machine reflecting a changed self-image.

Sinha closes the loop by removing the friction at the end. Convenience, not virtue, is what makes take-back work – in parts of Kerala, modest price cuts on collection pushed volumes up rather than down. d

BIJOY ALAYLO, Director and COO, TP-Link

"AI is a thing which should be working at the backend. If you have to promote it for somebody to use it, it is not actually working for you. The decision-making control has to always be firmly in the customer's hands every single time. If they want a certain device to work in a certain way, it has to be configured from their end, and not something decided by a machine or AI on their behalf."

MAYANK SINHA
Business Head, Selsmart

"Brands are now embracing circularity and I don't say it in terms of a fancy word. They have understood that if there is a business model where you can build exchanges, you can build take-back by providing an attractive value and you can go to a home and pick it up, the customer is embracing it and brands are embracing it. Companies like us are able to extract 27 metals at 99.9% purity, which means that they can be reused in original manufacturing. If that link is there and the processes you have are mirrored to what a manufacturer needs, then those materials become valuable."

SANJAY CHITKARA
Director and co-CSMO, LG

"We don't treat a long life cycle as a business threat. We feel it's an opportunity to build long-time brand loyalty with our customers... We don't push very aggressively the artificial obsolescence of our product, like slowing down the software or there being no spares for 5-10 years... What we believe is that our upgrades are basically based on human aspiration to evolve... they (consumers) change their functionally working products because the new product reflects their new image, new personality, new taste for the design and features and their new status."